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Can a subnet save itself from deregistration? A case study on Polaris Cloud AI

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deregistration? A Case Study on Polaris Cloud AI

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The rapid ascent of artificial intelligence has made compute power one of the world’s most valuable and contested resources. Today, access to high- performance GPUs most often rests in the hands of centralized monopolies. These private, closed systems, with inflated pricing, keep innovation stagnated.

@polariscloudai, operating on JBittensor’s Subnet 49, attempts to challenge this narrative, by working towards building a decentralized, transparent, and user-owned marketplace for compute power that fuels global accessibility.

Polaris is one of many subnets bringing cheap and reliable compute to Bittensor, JChutes_ai, JLium_io, JTargonCompute, to name a few.

Since their registration in October 2024, the team has been working towards building out a decentralized GPU platform that coordinates supply and demand through on-chain mechanisms. The platform, in theory, allows contributors to provide GPU resources, while users can rent compute for AI tasks (like model inference or large-scale training).

The theory part comes in because Polaris' updates, development, and scaling have been lack-lustre and insufficient, plagued by delays and issues within their small network of miners, and validators.

While communication from the team on their official X page is strong, and weekly scheduled Discord calls keep the community informed on their progress, there is very little transparency on the part of the team on when and if the network goes down, when and why tokens will be burnt, and why, so frequently, promised

updates and rollouts become delayed.

Communication issues also arise in the lack of documentation for the project. Although they have a great website, many of their features are not yet built out, and no whitepaper for the project is linked.

The following information gathering happened through parsing the team's Discord, X account, Github and watching interviews, not the most reliable or accessible way to learn about a project.

The infrastructure promised by Polaris seems on the surface to be strong and promising. Key features shared by Polaris' team include:

- Decentralized Compute Access: GPU and CPU contributions are coordinated on chain

- Validator–Miner Economy: Validators verify miner performance, uptime, and authenticity, while miners contribute compute to earn emissions.

- Node Manager Tooling: An intuitive interface makes onboarding simple, even for potential participants without deep expertise.

The Node Manager, in particular, posits to lower the barrier of entry, enabling individuals and institutions to contribute machines, monitor workloads, and begin earning TAO tokens within minutes.

Polaris emphasizes its infrastructure's fairness through a "performance- based reward system". Participation requires a minimum Proof-of-Work score of 0.03, filtering out low-quality or unreliable resources. The lower your contribution, the higher your risk of getting no reward at all.

Rewards are determined through a scoring architecture that considers uptime, container management, and compute power. Bonuses are awarded for high availability and active workload management.

Polaris is also building out an infrastructure layer designed for AI-native workloads. Researchers, machine learning engineers, and developers can deploy jobs, monitor performance, and scale applications. The upcoming AI Studio and Transformer Lab promise to further expand these capabilities.

Subnet owner Fred has described Polaris as being at a "tipping point." Months of steady development have brought the project to the verge of a growth phase, or complete and utter failure.

In his own words: "We have been pushing up, and up, and up the hill. We are starting to get to the portion of the hill where the ball starts to roll down, where we start to see real growth in the subnet that we have not seen before."

That growth trajectory is tied to a near-term objective, to generate sustainable revenue by offering scalable machine rentals and compute mining services reliably.

Reliability, availability, and security are now the critical factors as Polaris transitions from development to commercialization.

Challenges have plagued the Polaris team for the past few months. Miners in the subnet's Discord are frequently seen dissenting, sometimes for the team's lack of updates, not pushing out deliverables on time, and the latest, a string of security exploits after a recent roll out. The team frequently turns off mining for weeks at a time, leaving the unhappy miners wondering and the price of alpha token tanking.

With the subnet's ADR near 1, things aren't looking too good for Polaris. Their vision is ambitious, to be the "OpenAI of Africa", the "AirBnb of GPUs". Polaris must prove its ability to compete with the few well-known and well- established compute providers in the space.

From @taostats

Words must turn into action and product, with performance and stability at the core of their next-slated releases. If they ever have a chance in succeeding, they will need to bring miners back on board, fix any security lapses, and ensure miners and validators can utilize the infrastructure without fail, without lapse, and without security concerns.

The chances of Polaris achieving its goals could be positive, provided the team continues its disciplined approach and refocuses on bringing miners back and unleashing new developments fast and on time. Fred's insistence on "getting things right before launching a product" could build credibility for Polaris within the ecosystem, but only if deregistration doesn't get them first.

Longer-term, even with the likes of Chutes, Lium and others, there is no lack of need for secure, reliable compute on the Bittensor network. If Polaris succeeds in creating an accessible, reliable, and transparent marketplace for compute, it really could bring decentralized AI infrastructure to Africa.

By opening access to compute power, rewarding contributors fairly, and creating a transparent marketplace for AI developers and enterprise, Polaris could be contributing toward a future where AI is not locked behind technocratic gates, but owned, governed, and scaled by the global community.

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Simplifying Bittensor subnet ecosystem through accessible, insightful articles. #TAO